

33번

In some parts of India there are temples to Sitala, who is a goddess of skin diseases. Historically, people in these regions made offerings to Sitala in order to protect themselves against smallpox. During the colonial period in India, the British introduced the smallpox vaccine, which ultimately led to the elimination of smallpox. This in turn led to a significant decline in the worship of Sitala as people no longer needed her assistance to avoid smallpox. Was it right for the British to introduce the smallpox vaccine given that it undermined the cultural practice of making offerings to Sitala? Or was this cultural imperialism? Should the British simply have lived and let live, or lived and let die as the case may be? That might seem harsh, but there are some scholars who argue for that. What is beyond dispute is that no matter how you answer that question, you are making a value judgment. In this example, choosing to live and let live isn't value-neutral; it's a choice that values cultural autonomy over the lives of those who would otherwise be saved.